

The State of Comon's Conjecture

Lael JOHN

Supervisor: Prof. N.
Vannieuwenhoven
KU Leuven

~~Mentor~~: Dr. D. Taufer
KU Leuven

*Both can be
mentioned as
supervisor.*

Thesis presented in
fulfillment of the requirements
for the degree of Master of Science
in Mathematics

Academic year 2025 -2026

Contents

1 Preliminaries Regarding Tensors	3
1.1 Tensors in an Algebraic Setting	3
1.2 Tensors in a Geometric Setting	4
1.3 Rank	6
1.4 Symmetric Tensors	7
2 Literature Review	10
2.1 Secant Varieties	10
2.2 Overview of Symmetric Tensor Decomposition	11
2.3 Overview of Valid Cases of the Conjecture	14
3 Constructions required for a Counterexample	15
3.1 History	15
3.1.1 Shitov's First Paper in 2019	15
3.1.2 Slicing a Tensor	15
3.1.3 Flattening a Tensor	16
3.1.4 Shitov's Subsequent Preprints	16
3.2 Major New Constructions	16
3.2.1 Adjoining Slices to Tensors	16
3.2.2 Generating Tensor Families modulo Slices	16
3.2.3 Cloning Tensors	16
3.3 Seigals Counterexample over $\mathbb{R}$	16
3.3.1 Details of Construction	16
3.3.2 Emulating Family Construction	16
4 Conclusion	19
4.1 Further Work	19

List of Figures

1	Example of a tensor $T \in \mathbb{F}^4 \otimes \mathbb{F}^3 \otimes \mathbb{F}^2$	1
2	Illustrating the tensor product of R -modules	3
3	Secant lines through a circle (and a limiting tangent line)	10
4	Slicing a tensor T along different modes	15
5	Flattening a tensor T	16
6	Adjoining a slice A to a tensor T	17
7	Family generated from a tensor T by a slice A	17
8	2 clone of a tensor T	18

1. Introduction

Upgrade to a chapter

The topic of this thesis centers around an open question about tensors. These are mathematical tools, used to describe relationships between multiple objects, allowing for some form of algebra to occur. In context of this work, the focus remains on how tensors can be built, where they lie, and how they can be broken down.

The state of Comon's conjecture (an open problem for the last 20 years) is not easily described. While mathematicians have chipped away at the number of cases where it remains valid, an answer in full generality over $\mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{C}$ remains unknown. The hope is that at least some of the work done in recent years can be highlighted as useful, paving the way towards a definitive counterexample or proof. This question merits study because of the powerful nature of tensors as descriptors of relationships. Tensors find their use in quantum mechanics, general relativity [9], chemometrics, psychometrics[28], and signal processing [17] — to name some examples. In each of these cases, knowing how important a feature of the relationship symmetry is would play a vital role in analysing procedures and algorithms that take for granted that symmetry is the more "natural" state of affairs. This forms the guiding idea behind the ideas and techniques explored during this thesis.

{ Can be useful to expand a bit on why one may be interested in tensor rank.
e.g. matrix multiplication tensor.

Comon's Conjecture

At its heart, Comon's Conjecture centers around 2 central themes: rank and symmetry in tensors. Rank (see 1.3.3) describes how a tensor can be decomposed into simpler constituent tensors, and symmetry (see 1.4.2) describes how tensors behave under permutation actions.

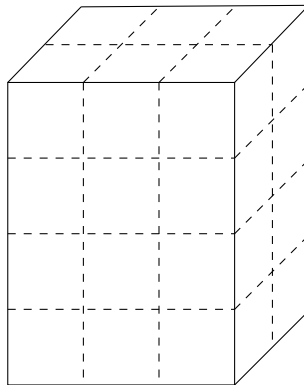


Figure 1: Example of a tensor $T \in \mathbb{F}^4 \otimes \mathbb{F}^3 \otimes \mathbb{F}^2$

The conjecture was first stated openly in July 2008 at "Geometry and Representation Theory of Tensors for Computer Science, Statistics and Other Areas" - a workshop organised at the American Institute for Mathematics [18] in the group focusing on "Multilinear Techniques in Data Analysis and Signal Processing". The conjecture as stated in the report is as follows

Conjecture 1 (Comon). *Do the rank and symmetric rank of T always coincide, where T is a real or complex tensor?*

The report also covered work done previously by Comon et al. [13] where they also showed that the conjecture held for situations when the symmetric rank was at least as large as the dimension, or when the order (see 1.1.1) of T is sufficiently large. Since 2008, the mathematical community has proved the conjecture true under various assumptions (see 2.2).

In 2019, Shitov [21] proposed the construction of a counterexample living in $(\mathbb{C}^{800})^{\otimes 3}$ with symmetric rank at least 904, and a rank of at most 903. In 2024 however, an erratum published [14] showed a flaw in the construction, rendering the conjecture still open, at least for the complex case. In the intervening time, a paper published by Seigal and Wang [27] demonstrated the construction of a real, order 6, symmetric tensor with real rank 30913 and symmetric rank 30914, disproving the conjecture for the real case. This paper built on constructions described in Shitov [22], a preprint, whose ideas have been developed further in subsequent preprints [23] and [24].

The following chapters and sections highlight important terminology required to state and describe the setting of Comon's conjecture, highlight the work done to prove the conjecture in the past, and finally to describe the major constructions required to construct the real counterexample.

Add:

- Overview of the chapters
- Main contribution of the thesis

Chapter 1

Preliminaries Regarding Tensors

1.1 Tensors in an Algebraic Setting

The most abstract way of thinking about tensors is when describing them as elements of the tensor product of modules. Consider A, B and P as being R -modules, where R is a ring. Then any mapping $t : A \times B \rightarrow P$ that is bi-linear in nature is described by acting on elements in this manner: $t(\lambda a, b) = t(a, \lambda b) = \lambda t(a, b)$, where $a \in A, b \in B, \lambda \in R$ and $t(a, b) \in P$.

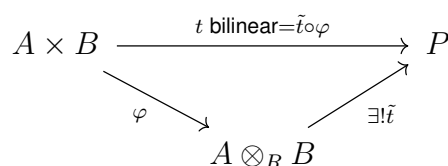


Figure 2: Illustrating the tensor product of R -modules

Such a bilinear (or even multilinear mapping) between R -modules can be represented by an element lying in their tensor product, such that the following diagram of modules commutes [26] (illustrated specifically for the case mentioned above in Figure 2)

While such a description is useful when dealing with talking about how any general elements lying in spaces can be combined, this description lacks some of the necessary details required for actually computing what a tensor *is*, or even how it can be represented. ?

A more useful approach to tensors is to begin from linear algebra. As matrices represent linear transformations between vector spaces V and W , so d -way arrays can be used to represent multilinear relationships between vector spaces $V_1, V_2 \dots V_d$. Diving deeper into this analogy, matrices do behave as either bilinear maps from the product $V \times W \rightarrow \mathbb{F}$, or as linear maps $W^* \rightarrow V^*$. This hybrid nature of matrices is in fact a reflection of the fact that matrices are order 2 tensors. Since computing elements of the matrix A_{ij} depends on a choice of bases for both vector spaces V and W , an analogous choice of bases must be made to describe the order d tensor $T \in V_1 \otimes V_2 \otimes \dots \otimes V_d$.

For the purposes of this thesis, unless specified, each vector space will be considered over $\mathbb{F} = \mathbb{R}$ or $\mathbb{C}$, with its standard ordered basis $\{e_i\}_{i=1}^n$ where $e_i(j) = \delta_{i,j}$. Accordingly, each vector space V_i has a dimension n_i .

Definition 1.1.1 (Order of a Tensor). A tensor T is said to be a d -order tensor, if $T \in V_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes V_d$.

Let $T := v_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes v_d$ be an order- d tensor, with each component $v_i \in V_i$ a vector with components $v_i(j)$ according to the standard ordered basis of the corresponding vector space. Then the elements of the d -way array that corresponds to T can be given in the following manner

$$T(k_1, k_2, \dots, k_d) = \prod_{i=1}^d v_i(k_i),$$

where $0 \leq k_i \leq n_i$ — the dimension of each corresponding vector space V_i .

T as defined above can be seen in the following manner

1. as a multilinear mapping between $V_1^* \times V_2^* \times \cdots \times V_d^* \rightarrow \mathbb{F}$ (extending the analogue of looking at matrices as bilinear forms)

$$(f_1, f_2, \dots, f_d) \mapsto \prod_{i=1}^d f_i(v_i)$$

2. as a linear mapping from $V_i^* \rightarrow V_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes V_{i-1} \otimes V_{i+1} \otimes \cdots \otimes V_d =: V_i$ (moving from a space of order- d tensors to order- $d-1$)

$$f_i \mapsto f_i(v_i)(v_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes v_{i-1} \otimes v_{i+1} \otimes \cdots \otimes v_d)$$

3. as the dual of this previously defined linear map, now going from $V_i^* \rightarrow V_i$ (moving now from order- d to a vector collinear to v_i)

$$(f_j)_{j \neq i} \mapsto \left(\prod_{j \neq i} f_j(v_j) \right)$$

Each of these above viewpoints also corresponds to an appropriate transformation of the representative d -way array chosen, either to a scalar, $d-1$ -way array or a vector respectively [17]. In fact scalars and vectors now can also be seen as tensors of orders 0 and 1 respectively.

1.2 Tensors in a Geometric Setting

I suggest to focus on the algebra.

As with any textbook in linear algebra, working algebraically helps in terms of computation, but concepts rarely exist only algebraically. Matrices (and by extension tensors), physically describe how points can be transported from one space to another — making them not just maps between algebraic structures, but also indicating a geometric nature.

does this viewpoint have a particular name?

To start with, 2×2 matrices can be seen as points lying in the space $Mat(2, \mathbb{F})$, or as elements of $\mathbb{F}^4$. Adding further constraints to them: requiring the matrices to have a non-vanishing determinant, or a unit determinant, or even all entries as positive further allows us to look at these as points lying in $GL(2, \mathbb{F})$, $SL(2, \mathbb{F})$ or $Mat(2, \mathbb{F})_{\geq 0}$ respectively. Each of these examples correspond to a well studied geometric space.

Moving to the case of order- d tensors, consider again a non-zero tensor $T := v_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes v_d$. Because tensors are importantly multilinear as mappings, this means that none of the individual component vectors $v_i = 0$. Then for each individual V_i , the non-zero vector v_i lies on a unique line through the origin $[v_i]$, allowing for a map between $V_i \rightarrow \mathbb{P}V_i$, the projectivisation of V_i . Note here that when moving to the projectivisation, even though the number of coordinates we use to describe v_i is n_i , the space $\mathbb{P}V_i$ has dimension $n_i - 1$.

The component vectors of T can now be written as a tuple lying in the Cartesian product of d projective spaces i.e. $([v_1], \dots, [v_d]) \in \mathbb{P}V_1 \times \cdots \times \mathbb{P}V_d$. A next natural question that arises is to see if such a tuple can be seen as lying in a much larger projective space, and this turns out to have an affirmative answer.

Definition 1.2.1 (Segre Mapping). Define $\Sigma : \mathbb{P}V_1 \times \cdots \times \mathbb{P}V_d \rightarrow \mathbb{P}V$ as the following mapping

$$([v_1], \dots, [v_d]) \mapsto [v_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes v_d]$$

The image point lies in the projectivisation of V , a vector space over $\mathbb{F}$ of dimension $\prod_{i=1}^d n_i$. Specifically all the image points lie in $\mathbb{P}(V_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes V_d) \subseteq \mathbb{P}V$ [25]

The existence of such a mapping allows for non-zero order- d tensors (of the same form as 1.3.1) to be represented as points lying on this new *Segre variety*.

Lemma 1.2.1. *The Segre mapping as defined above is an injective map, but not surjective.*

Proof. This mapping is well defined (all tuples have an image in $\mathbb{P}V$, and the image of a tuple is unique). However, the Segre mapping is generally not surjective. Not every point in $\mathbb{P}V$ can be written as the image of a single tuple of the form $([v_1], \dots, [v_d])$. A simple example is when dealing with 3×3 matrices $[e_1 \otimes e_1 + e_2 \otimes e_2]$ cannot be written as the image of a single tuple of $([v_1], [v_2])$.

Starting with two distinct tuples $([a_1], \dots, [a_d])$ and $([b_1], \dots, [b_d])$ gives us at least one pair of vectors a_i, b_i that do not lie on the same line through the origin in V_i . The resulting images under Σ are the tensors $[a_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes a_d]$ and $[b_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes b_d]$ that differ at least in one component in the d -way arrays, and therefore represent distinct families of tensors. Thus the Segre mapping is injective, and ends up being referred to as the *Segre embedding* in algebraic geometry literature. $\square$

This doesn't seem to prove the claim.

Why is it important to consider both?

Both aspects prove useful as tools to study tensors. Explicit computation is far easier when working with tensors algebraically, and thus much more easily applicable in fields other than mathematics, once problems have been stated in appropriate terms. On the other hand, dealing with the geometry of tensors allows for a much better examination of edge cases and boundary conditions, particularly useful when working with proofs about general properties that should apply to tensors.

1.3 Rank

While the previous two sections covered the nature of tensors, it is necessary to figure out how tensors can be constructed, since the Segre embedding example shows that there are tensors that cannot be constructed as simply the tensor product of vectors — as an analogy, recall not all vectors in a vector space can be written as only scaled basis vectors.

Definition 1.3.1 (Elementary Tensor). Consider a tensor $T := v_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes v_d \in V_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes V_d$, an order d tensor. Since T can be written explicitly as the tensor product of d vectors, it is known as an elementary tensor. Equivalent names for such tensors present in literature are *rank one* and *decomposable*.

The Segre Variety (as defined in 1.2.1) contains exactly the images of all the non-zero *elementary* tensors in a given tensor product. This still leaves open the question of how tensors of higher rank can be represented, which has been tackled successfully in the literature by the development of *secant varieties* [4] (see 2.2)

Using these elementary tensors as building blocks now provides a way to describe the construction of more general tensors.

Definition 1.3.2 (Tensor Decomposition). Consider a general tensor $T \in V_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes V_d$. A decomposition of T consists of writing T as a sum of elementary tensors

$$T = \sum_{i=1}^s v_1^i \otimes \cdots \otimes v_d^i$$

now with each of the $v_j^i \in V_i$. [28]

For any given tensor T now, there can exist multiple decompositions, not just depending on the choice of basis vectors for each V_i . A further natural question to ask is if there is a shortest decomposition, and if such a decomposition is unique.

Definition 1.3.3 (Tensor Rank). The rank of a tensor T is the minimal length of any possible decomposition of T .

Tensor rank always exists, because tensors can always be written in terms of elementary tensors. Computing the rank of a given tensor is not an easy problem, but it has given rise to multiple approaches in the literature that rely on both the algebraic properties of tensors and associated transformations, and the geometric properties of the varieties on which these tensors lie. Tensor rank also remains invariant of decomposition and is one of the two key ingredients required to state Comon's Conjecture.

A further question that can be asked is whether "perturbing" a tensor changes its rank. This leads to the notion of describing rank when it is seen as the limit of a sequence.

Definition 1.3.4 (Border Rank). A tensor T has border rank r if it can be expressed as a limit of a sequence of tensors of rank r , but not for any sequence of tensors with rank $s < r$. Conventional notation is to denote border rank with $\text{Rank}(T) = r$

The notion of border rank comes in use when working with secant varieties, as a tool to help compute rank. Tensors can have differing ranks and border ranks

Example Consider $T := a_1 \otimes b_1 \otimes c_1 + a_1 \otimes b_1 \otimes c_2 + a_1 \otimes b_2 \otimes c_1 + a_2 \otimes b_1 \otimes c_2$. Then the rank of this tensor is 3, but one can write T as the limit of tensors of rank 2 in the following manner

$$T(s) = \frac{1}{s} ((1 - 1/a_1)a_1 \otimes b_1 \otimes c_1 + (a_1 + sa_2) \otimes (b_1 + sb_2) \otimes (c_1 + sc_2))$$

[17]

1.4 Symmetric Tensors

The other half of Comon's Conjecture revolves around tensors that exhibit symmetric properties. These become valuable in applications simply because the symmetry means that they require "less" information to be constructed. What makes a tensor symmetric is the next logical question to tackle, and necessitates a definition of how permutations act on a given tensor.

Given $\sigma \in S_d$, an element representing a permutation of d distinct elements, then one can define the permutation action on a tensor as follows

Definition 1.4.1 (Permutation of a Tensor). Let $T := v_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes v_d \in V_1 \otimes \cdots \otimes V_d$, where $V_i = V_j$. Then $\sigma \in S_d$ acts on T in the following manner

$$\sigma \cdot T = v_{\sigma(1)} \otimes \cdots \otimes v_{\sigma(d)}$$

Note here that we do require that all the vector spaces are the same, to keep the mapping well defined. ~~If the vector spaces were allowed to differ in dimension, then this would no longer be a group action, since the underlying set keeps changing (shuffling around.)~~ This also allows for the use of notation $T \in V^{\otimes d}$. ~~Such tensors are also referred to as cubical.~~

The definition of a symmetric tensor follows almost immediately

Definition 1.4.2 (Symmetric Tensor). Consider a tensor $T \in V^{\otimes d}$. T is said to be symmetric if the following equality holds

$$T = \frac{1}{d!} \sum_{\sigma \in S_d} \sigma \cdot T$$

The requirement of $T = \sigma \cdot T$ for all $\sigma \in S_d$ follows as a consequence of this definition. [13].

Further, since every tensor can be expressed as a decomposition (see 1.3.2), it follows that symmetric tensors can also be decomposed into a sum of elementary *symmetric tensors*, where now each is of the form $v^{\otimes d}$ by symmetry requirements.

It is clear that not every tensor can be seen as symmetric, and therefore the subset of all order d tensors that are symmetric is denoted $S^d(\mathbb{F}^n) \subseteq \mathbb{F}^n$ — notation usually reserved for homogenous polynomials in n variables of fixed degree d . In fact one can show that these spaces are isomorphic to each other. This equivalence is a powerful tool that allows for an interchange of polynomial and tensor notation (when appropriate).

Can you clarify with some formula, for example

who is S_d ?

Symmetric Tensors and Homogenous Polynomials of Fixed Degree

A polynomial $f \in \mathbb{F}[x_1, \dots, x_n]_d$ is of the form

$$f(x_1, \dots, x_n) = \sum_{a_i \geq 0, \sum_i a_i = d} \lambda_{(a_1, \dots, a_n)} \prod_{i=1}^n x_i^{a_i} \quad ?$$

where all the coefficients $\lambda_{(a_1, \dots, a_n)} \in \mathbb{F}$. Here the following notation is commonly used in the literature — $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n)$ and $\alpha = (a_1, a_2, \dots, a_n) \in (\mathbb{N} \cup \{0\})^n$. Then $\mathbf{x}^\alpha = \prod_{i=1}^n x_i^{a_i}$. Further $|\alpha| = \sum_i a_i$, so the homogenous polynomial as stated above can be rewritten as

$$f(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{|\alpha|=d} \lambda_\alpha \mathbf{x}^\alpha \quad ?$$

The following proposition is standard in tensor decomposition literature, but is stated again for convenience.

Proposition 1.4.1. *For fixed values of $d, n > 0$, there is a mapping*

$$\Phi_d : \mathbb{F}[x_1, \dots, x_n]_d \rightarrow S^d(\mathbb{F}^n) \quad ?$$

an isomorphism of vector spaces over $\mathbb{F}$.

Proof. Define the mapping first for all degree d monomials $\mathbf{x}^\alpha$ as

$$\mathbf{x}^\alpha := \prod_{i=1}^n x_i^{a_i} \mapsto \frac{1}{d!} \sum_{\sigma \in S_d} \sigma \cdot \left(\bigotimes_{i=1}^n e_i^{a_i} \right) \quad ? \quad \text{q. is this a linear map?}$$

Thus each monomial is mapped to a symmetric tensor (by construction).

To make sure this mapping is well defined, it is necessary to also emphasise that Φ must be a linear mapping (i.e. it must preserve addition and scalar multiplication in $\mathbb{F}[x_1, \dots, x_n]_d$). This ensures that every degree d homogenous polynomial has only one image symmetric tensor.

With this definition, Φ is an homomorphism of vector spaces because for $\lambda \in \mathbb{F}$

$$\Phi(\lambda \mathbf{x}^\alpha + \mathbf{x}^\beta) = \lambda \left(\frac{1}{d!} \sum_{\sigma \in S_d} \sigma \cdot \left(\bigotimes_{i=1}^n e_i^{a_i} \right) \right) + \left(\frac{1}{d!} \sum_{\sigma \in S_d} \sigma \cdot \left(\bigotimes_{i=1}^n e_i^{b_i} \right) \right) = \lambda \Phi(\mathbf{x}^\alpha) + \Phi(\mathbf{x}^\beta) \quad ?$$

Further, every elementary symmetric tensor $v^{\otimes d} = (\sum_{i=1}^n v_i e_i)^{\otimes d}$ can be seen as the image of the d -th power of a linear form — $(\sum_{i=1}^n v_i x_i)^d$. Since every symmetric tensor has a symmetric tensor decomposition, Φ must also be surjective.

Finally, consider two distinct monomials $\mathbf{x}^\alpha, \mathbf{x}^\beta \in \mathbb{F}[x_1, \dots, x_n]_d$ with $a_j \neq b_j$ for at least one $0 \leq j \leq n$. Their images then are also distinct under Φ because every term in the sum of the image is distinct. $\square$

Thus there exists an isomorphism between these two vector spaces. In fact Φ_d can be seen as a component of a larger isomorphism between graded vector spaces, [13].

Symmetric Tensors and the Veronese Mapping

In addition to being in bijection with homogenous polynomials of fixed degree, as a result of their symmetry, symmetric tensors can be seen as points in a space of much lower dimension. As earlier, this allows for the elementary symmetric tensors to be mapped to a variety.

Definition 1.4.3 (Veronese Mapping). Define the mapping $\nu_d : \mathbb{P}\mathbb{F}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{P}\mathbb{F}^{\binom{n+d-1}{d}}$ in the following manner

$$[v_1 : \dots : v_n] \mapsto [v_1^d : v_1^{d-1}v_2 : \dots : v_n^d]$$

now where all the $v_i \in \mathbb{F}$.

Since non-zero elementary symmetric tensors are of the form $(\sum_{i=1}^n v_i e_i)^{\otimes d}$ this mapping embeds the constituent vectors into the Veronese variety. [18] As previously, this mapping is not surjective.

Since $\binom{n+d-1}{d} < (n)^d$ for all $d > 1, n > 1$, we know that the Veronese variety lies in a lower dimensional space than the Segre, and a mapping can be constructed to see the image of $\nu_d(\mathbb{P}\mathbb{F}^n) \in \Sigma(\mathbb{P}\mathbb{F}^n \times \dots \times \mathbb{P}\mathbb{F}^n)$ since elementary symmetric tensors are also tensors. In fact the image of the diagonal $\Delta := \{([x], \dots, [x]) \mid [x] \in \mathbb{P}\mathbb{F}^n\}$ under the Segre mapping is exactly the embedding of the Veronese into the Segre mapping.

Armed with this background of symmetric tensors and rank, and with an understanding of how to view tensors as both multi-way arrays, some of them as homogenous polynomials, and some of them as points in space, the next step to be taken in this thesis is to cover the literature around Comon's Conjecture.

I suggest to avoid all constructions involving projective space.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

Since the stating of the problem in 2008, there has been a substantial amount of work done to arrive at a conclusive final resolution. This body of work relies on the geometric construction of secant varieties and how they relate to the question of computing rank and symmetric rank.

2.1 Secant Varieties

I suggest to focus on the algebra.

The notion of studying secants to a given geometric object is not novel, but doing so sheds more light on the description of tensors as lying in projective space. Considering a curve in a vector space, the secant line joining any two distinct points is described exactly by all the linear combinations of the points. This analogy is the inspiration for the following definition.

Definition 2.1.1 (r -th Secant Variety to X). Let $X \subset \mathbb{P}V$ be a projective variety. Then the r -th secant variety to X , denoted $\sigma_r(X)$ is defined as

$$\sigma_r(X) := \overline{\bigcup_{x_1, \dots, x_r \in X} \mathbb{P}_{x_1, \dots, x_r}}$$

Here $\mathbb{P}_{x_1, \dots, x_r}$ (for $x_1, \dots, x_r$ lying in general position) is the projectivisation of the r -dimensional hyperplane defined by these r points. The bar denotes the Zariski closure in $\mathbb{P}V$, covering the cases where the r points chosen may not lie in general position, particularly also when all the r chosen points coincide leading to the corresponding tangent hyperplane.

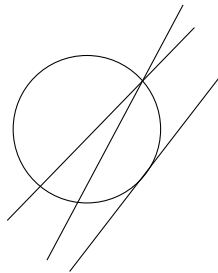


Figure 3: Secant lines through a circle (and a limiting tangent line)

Observation. It is clear from the definition above that successive secant varieties are nested, with $\sigma_0(X) = X$, $\sigma_1(X)$ describing all the tangent lines to X , and so on, such that $\sigma_{r-1}(X) \subseteq \sigma_r(X)$. Such a sequence of nested geometric objects must stabilise, for reasons of dimension.

Remark. While this geometric object is easy to describe with the notation above, computing the ideals for such a variety, or even the equations required to cut such a variety out form about half of the body of work surrounding Comon's conjecture. The following papers [7, 8, 3] develop alternative geometric tools to secant varieties that are easier to compute.

Since elementary tensors can be seen as lying on either the Segre or Veronese embedding, the r -th secant varieties to each of these describe all the tensors of *border rank* at most r . Note here that it is border rank that because of the closure in the definition of the secant variety. To describe all tensors of *rank* at most r , it is enough to look at the *interior* points of the r -th secant variety, this interior again being under the Zariski topology on $\mathbb{P}V$.

2.2 Overview of Symmetric Tensor Decomposition

As mentioned in the introduction Comon et al. [13] showed symmetric rank and rank coincided for tensors of "large enough" order — a notion that became concrete in later literature. The authors also point out as a result of the Veronese embedding (see 1.4.3), the rank of a symmetric tensor $T \in S^d(\mathbb{C}^n)$ cannot be more than $\binom{n+d-1}{d}$.

Since $S^d(\mathbb{C}^n) \subseteq (\mathbb{C}^n)^{\otimes d}$, they pointed out that for all $T \in S^d(\mathbb{C}^n)$, $\text{Rank}(T) \leq \text{Rank}_S(T)$. Their major result was that the conjecture holds "generically" (i.e almost everywhere) whenever $\text{Rank}_S(T) \leq n$, the dimension of the underlying vector space. In fact for every $T \in S^d(\mathbb{C}^n)$, they showed that Comon's conjecture holds if $\text{Rank}_S(T) = 1, 2$.

Brachat et al. [5], in 2010 proposed a new algorithm for symmetric tensor decomposition beginning with the relationship between symmetric tensor decomposition and the secant varieties of a Veronese variety (see Section 2.1). Their resulting algorithm required a reformulation of the problem in a dual space, and Hankel operators. [INCLUDE THIS?]

A convergent approach to Comon's conjecture arises from a classical problem in number theory — the Waring decomposition of a number. This problem then gets restated into the Waring problem for polynomials as follows: *What is the minimum number of linear polynomials required such that a linear combination of them to the d th power is equal to a homogenous degree d polynomial?*

A solution to the polynomial Waring problem definitely solves the first issue of computing symmetric tensor decompositions (see 1.4). This problem was solved by Alexander and Hirschowitz in 1995, where they showed that $\sigma_r(\nu_d(\mathbb{P}\mathbb{F}^{n+1}))$ - the r -th secant variety to the d -th Veronese embedding of $\mathbb{F}^{n+1}$ - is of expected dimension with 5 exceptional cases. Brambilla and Ottaviani [6] in 2008 gave a self-contained proof of the theorem, with some simplifications, particularly in the case of order 3 symmetric tensors.

Want you probably intend a first form of the conjecture, now a description of the rank and of symmetry of Ch. 1.

How does rank connect. relate to computing the decomposition?

which?

What's the narrative here? What info do you want to impart?

How does this relate to the problem?

How does this relate to the way you want to tell?

How was it solved by A4 1995?

I suggest to focus on¹² the algebra side of things

Landsberg [17], in his textbook describes the conjecture in terms of (border) rank preserving pairs of projective varieties.

Definition 2.2.1 ((Border) Rank Preserving Pair). $X \subseteq \mathbb{P}^n$, a variety, and $L \subseteq \mathbb{P}^n$ a linear subspace when taken together as (X, L) are a (border) rank preserving pair if $\langle (X \cap L)_{red} \rangle = L$ and $\text{Rank}(X|_L) = \text{Rank}(X|_{(X \cap L)_{red}})$. (A similar condition holds for border rank, but this can now be stated in terms of secant varieties as $\sigma_r(X) \cap L = \sigma_r((X \cap L)_{red})$). Here $(X \cap L)_{red}$ refers to the intersection without any points of non-unit multiplicity. and Rank is now seen as a function from $\langle X \rangle \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$

Remark. This translates the statement of Comon's conjecture from algebra to a statement about (secant) varieties lying in some projective space. In this restatement, $\Sigma(\mathbb{P}^n \times \cdots \times \mathbb{P}^n)$ (the d -fold Segre embedding) and $\mathbb{P}(S^d(\mathbb{F}^n))$ (all the lines passing through the d -th Veronese) are required to be a rank-preserving pair.

Ballico and Bernardi [1] in 2013 showed that that tensors lying on the tangent variety to a Veronese variety (see 1.4.3) must always have $\text{Rank} = \text{Rank}_S$. Their proof highlighted explicit algorithms for the computation of the rank of a tensor belonging to a given secant variety. Their computation involves describing how a point on the tangent variety can be expressed by lying on the linear span of a degree 2 zero-dimensional scheme.

While secant varieties are convenient geometric tools to use, Buczyńska and Buczyński [7] demonstrate how the commonly used practice of using the $(r+1) \times (r+1)$ minors of the catalecticant matrix to compute the generating equations for the secant variety are not sufficient for higher order Veronese varieties (order $\gg 2$). This paper resulted in the development of *cactus varieties*.

Oeding and Ottaviani [19] in 2013 contributed new algorithms for computing solutions to the polynomial Waring decomposition problem - equivalent to the computation of secant varieties to a given Veronese variety. They did so by further developing work done to define the eigenvectors of a tensor. Using these eigenvectors and Kozul flattenings allowed for an algorithm that could compute the Waring decomposition while also remaining valid for previously covered cases under the catalecticant matrix methodology.

Computing decompositions covers one half of the questions about symmetric rank. The other half concerning the uniqueness of a decomposition requires the definition of when a tensor is *identifiable*.

Definition 2.2.2 (Identifiability). A tensor T is said to be identifiable if it admits only one rank decomposition (modulo scaling by d -th roots of unity and permutations of summands)

Observation. This definition is equivalent to asking that an identifiable tensor lie on only one secant variety (again modulo permutations of points on the Segre embedding, and scaling factors)

Identifiability is a useful property when working with symmetric tensors because no further computation is required once a tensor decomposition is found. Particularly for the case of Comon's conjecture, the distinction between rank and symmetric rank (if such a tensor exists) implies that the tensor in question is *not* identifiable.

Suggest to rephrase without reference to varieties

How relevant?

How equiv?

How relevant to Comon's conj?

Generic identifiability is the idea that almost every point (i.e. a point in a dense open subset), is identifiable. Specific identifiability poses the opposite question - given a specific tensor T , does it admit a unique decomposition? Chiantini, Ottaviani and Vannieuwenhoven [12, 11] in 2 subsequent papers tackled both of these questions. Their earlier paper showed that a general symmetric tensor in $S^d(\mathbb{C}^{n+1})$ of sub-generic rank r was identifiable, provided $r \leq \binom{n+d}{d}/(n+1)$ (with exceptions again being covered by the Alexander-Hirschowitz theorem). Their second paper focused on showing what criteria could be called "effective" to determine if a given tensor was specifically identifiable. Criteria were designated effective if their conditions were satisfied by generic points (i.e. they were satisfied in an open, dense subset). One of the conclusions this paper reached was that Kruskal's criterion fell in line with this definition of "effectiveness".

Friedland [15] in 2016 focused not on the computation of the symmetric rank, but on the properties of symmetric tensors of a given symmetric rank. In particular the paper focused on showing that when a symmetric tensor can be unfolded into a matrix (see 3.1.3), then Comon's Conjecture held if the rank of the tensor when computed was either the rank of the matrix or the rank of the matrix + 1.

Zhang et al. [28] conclusively showed that Comon's conjecture held for all tensors where the rank of the tensor under consideration is not more than its order.

Ballico et al [2] at the end of 2018, refocused on the question of identifiability, and worked on refining Kruskal's criterion (sharp and algebraic in nature) into a geometric criterion that can be verified more easily. They concluded that Comon's conjecture holds for general tensors whose symmetric rank r is bounded above strictly by $\binom{n+e}{e}$ for a specific choice of e . This choice depended upon splitting the Segre product into two disjoint components and then imposing conditions on a set of points on the Segre that exhibited distinct behaviour when projected down to the first component versus the second. The authors of this paper clearly point out that even though they have increased the scope of validity of Comon's conjecture, Shitov's proposed counterexample [21] lies outside this scope and thus might have still been a plausible counterexample.

Bernardi et al. [4] in 2018 comprehensively covered the literature and algorithms required to understand how secant varieties become useful in establishing questions about (generic) rank for tensors, with an emphasis on symmetric tensors and the mapping to the Veronese variety. { Non relevant?

Casarotti et al. [10] proposed to improve the bounds for Comon's conjecture when working with flattenings, provided that equations for the secant varieties associated to the Veronese variety could be generated. Their result was that $h < \binom{n+\lfloor \frac{d}{2} \rfloor}{n}$, for a tensor having rank h implies that $\text{Rank}_S = h$, for cases where such generating determinantal equations were known.

Finally in [20] Seigal demonstrated that for all "cubic surfaces", Comon's conjecture does hold. (even up to border rank.) Here cubic surfaces were used to refer to the fact that under the identification with homogenous polynomials, order 3 symmetric tensors correspond to cubic polynomials, and thus their zero sets could be called cubic surfaces. She also used flattenings of tensors (see 3.1.3), dividing her proof into cases depending on the number of singularities on the cubic surfaces in question.

What about Shitov's work?

2.3 Overview of Valid Cases of the Conjecture

The current overview of the cases where Comon's Conjecture holds so far is as follows:

- For $T = \sum_{i=1}^s y_i^{\otimes d}$ and d "large enough" [13]. Here the large enough argument in the paper hinges on a classical result from algebraic geometry, stating that d points in $\mathbb{C}^n$ form the solution set of polynomial equations of degree $\leq d$
- For $T \in S^d(\mathbb{C}^n)$ and $\text{rank}_S(T) = 1, 2$ [13]
- For $T \in S^d V$, and $\text{rank}(T) \leq \frac{dn-d+1}{2}$ where V is a real or complex vector space with dimension n [18]
- For $T \in S^d(\mathbb{C}^n)$ for $(d, n) \in \{(3, 2), (4, 2), (3, 3)\}$ [15]
- In the case $d \geq 3, |\mathbb{F}| \geq 3, T \in S^d(\mathbb{F}^n)$ and $\text{rank}(T) \leq \text{rank}U(T) + 1$ (Here U denotes the flattening 3.1.3 of T in any direction, since T is symmetric all directions are equivalent) [15]
- When $T \in S^3(\mathbb{C}^n)$ and $\text{rank}(T) \leq 5$ or $\text{rank}_S(T) \leq 6$ [15]
- For $T \in S^d(\mathbb{F}^n)$ where $\text{rank}(T) \leq d$ where $\mathbb{F} = \mathbb{R}, \mathbb{C}$ [28]
- If T is a tensor belonging to a tangential variety to a Veronese variety [1]
- If $T \in \mathbb{C}^2 \otimes \mathbb{C}^n \otimes \mathbb{C}^n$ [8]
- For T being a Coppersmith-Winograd tensor [16]
- Casarotti [10] sets up two propositions that suggest whenever determinantal equations for secant varieties can be written down, Comon's conjecture should be *verifiable*
- Whenever a tensor T is cubic surface (real or complex) [20]

Chapter 3

Constructions required for a Counterexample

3.1 History

3.1.1 Shitov's First Paper in 2019

3.1.2 Slicing a Tensor

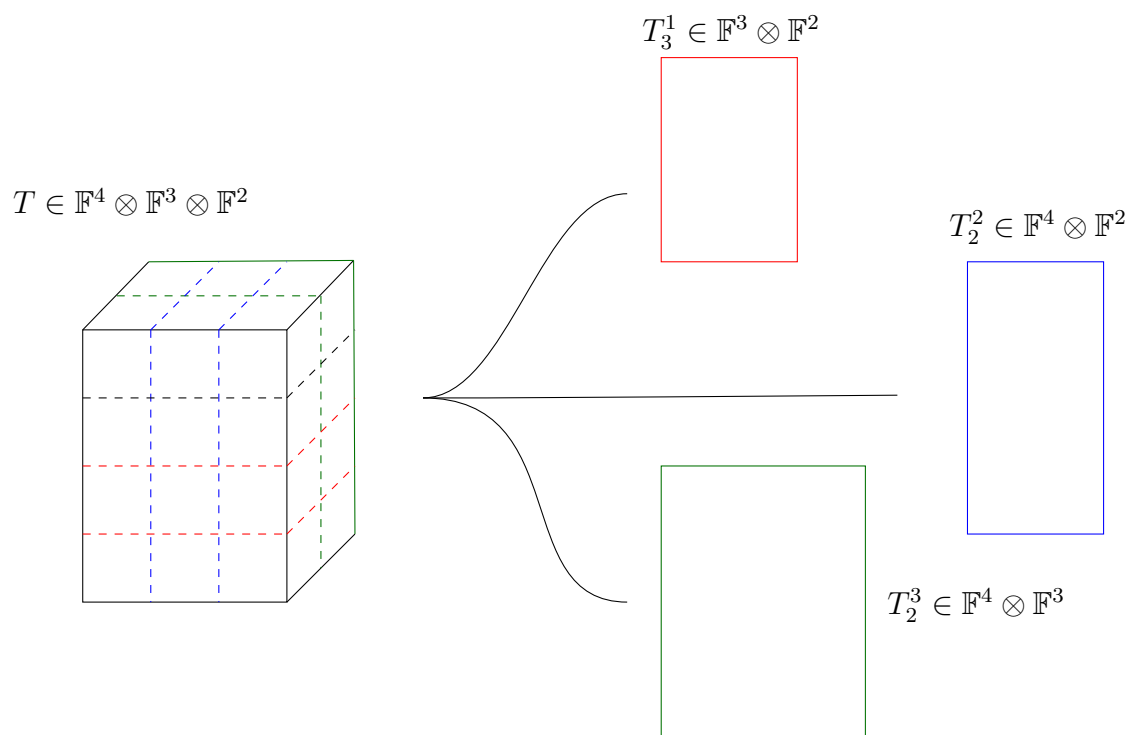
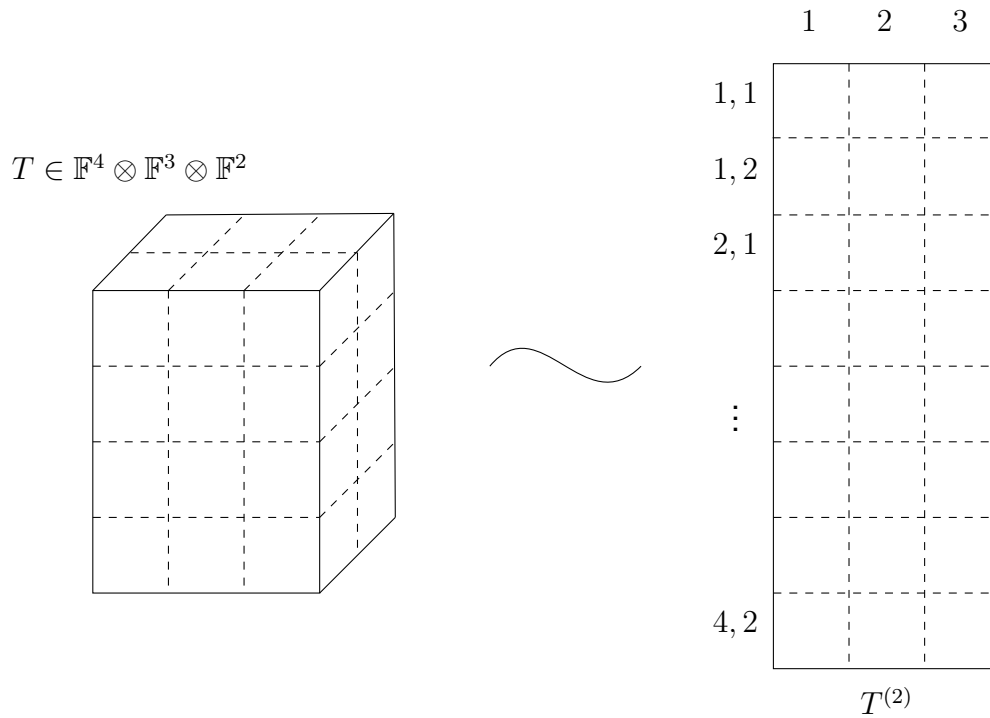
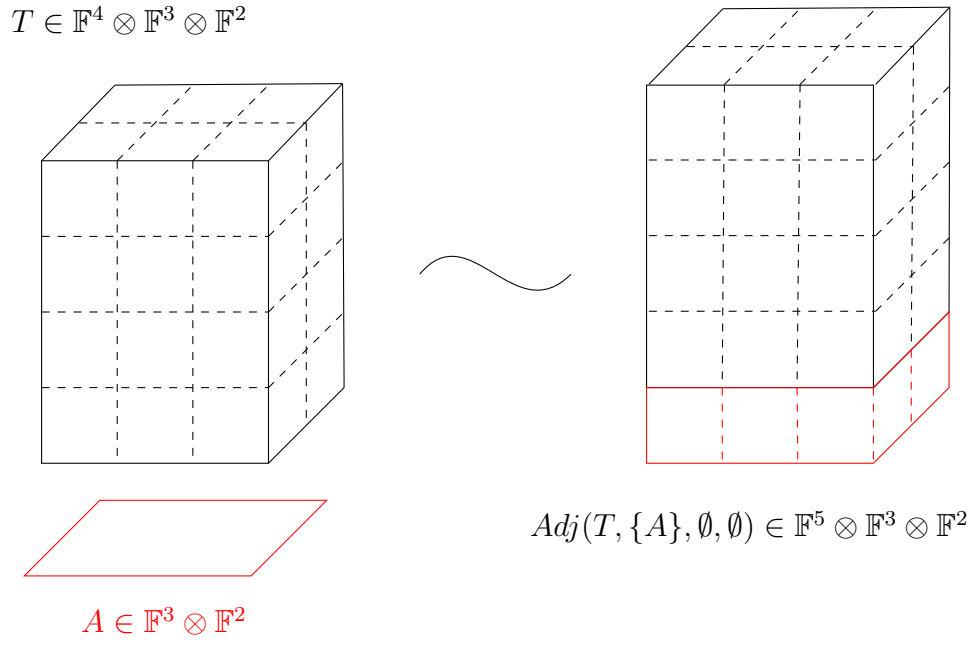
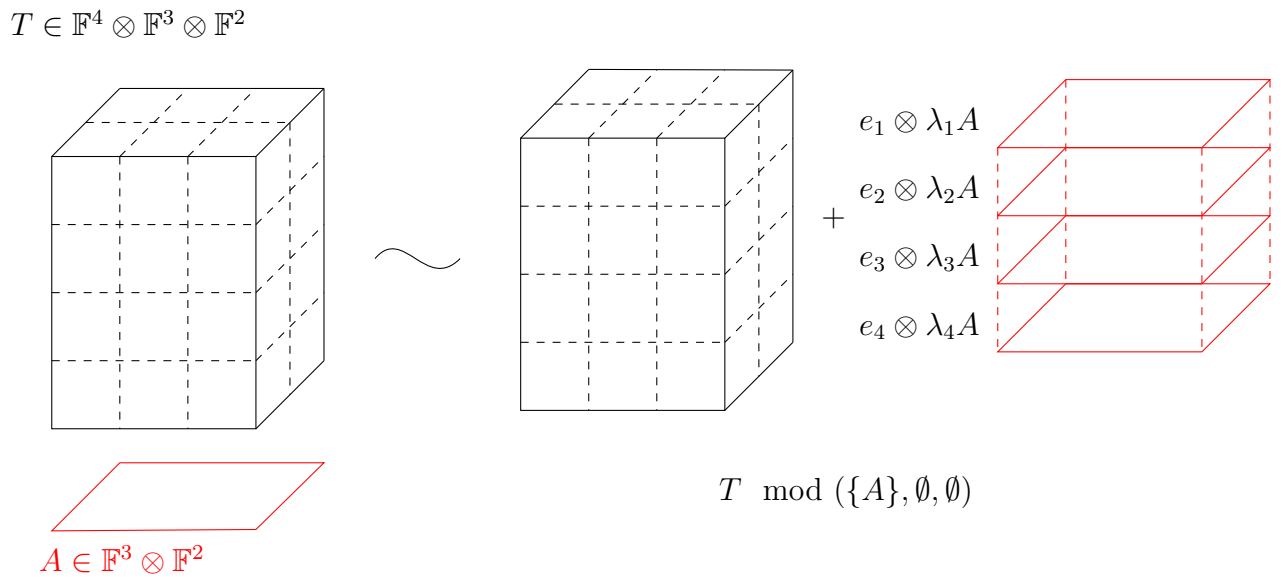
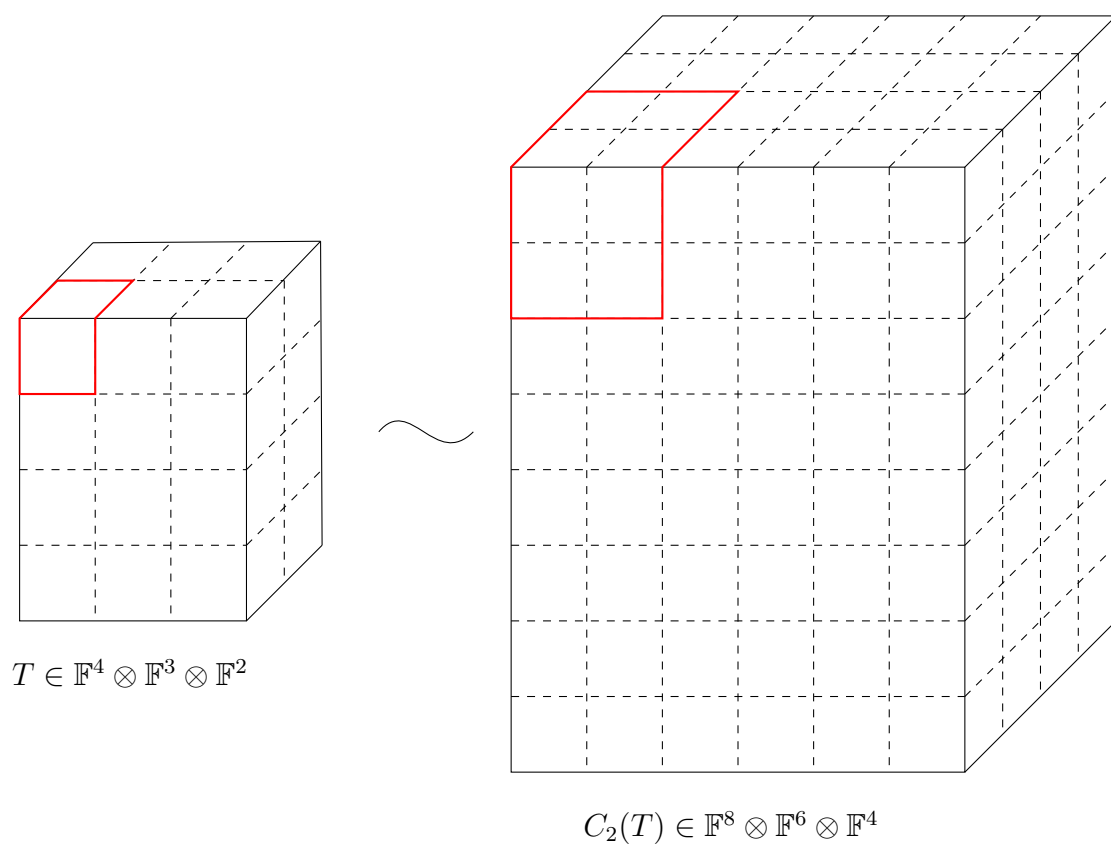


Figure 4: Slicing a tensor T along different modes

Figure 5: Flattening a tensor T **3.1.3 Flattening a Tensor****3.1.4 Shitov's Subsequent Preprints****3.2 Major New Constructions****3.2.1 Adjoining Slices to Tensors****3.2.2 Generating Tensor Families modulo Slices****3.2.3 Cloning Tensors****3.3 Seigals Counterexample over $\mathbb{R}$** **3.3.1 Details of Construction****3.3.2 Emulating Family Construction**


 Figure 6: Adjoining a slice A to a tensor T

 Figure 7: Family generated from a tensor T by a slice A

Figure 8: 2 clone of a tensor T

Chapter 4

Conclusion

4.1 Further Work

Bibliography

- [1] E. Ballico and A. Bernardi. “Tensor ranks on tangent developable of Segre varieties”. en. In: *Linear and Multilinear Algebra* 61.7 (July 2013), pp. 881–894. ISSN: 0308-1087, 1563-5139. DOI: [10.1080/03081087.2012.716430](https://doi.org/10.1080/03081087.2012.716430). URL: <http://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/03081087.2012.716430> (visited on 11/28/2025).
- [2] Edoardo Ballico et al. “Bounds on the tensor rank”. en. In: *Annali di Matematica* 197.6 (Dec. 2018), pp. 1771–1785. ISSN: 0373-3114, 1618-1891. DOI: [10.1007/s10231-018-0748-6](https://doi.org/10.1007/s10231-018-0748-6). URL: <http://link.springer.com/10.1007/s10231-018-0748-6> (visited on 12/30/2025).
- [3] Alessandra Bernardi and Daniele Taufer. “Waring, tangential and cactus decompositions”. en. In: *Journal de Mathématiques Pures et Appliquées* 143 (Nov. 2020), pp. 1–30. ISSN: 00217824. DOI: [10.1016/j.matpur.2020.07.003](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.matpur.2020.07.003). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0021782420301203> (visited on 01/07/2026).
- [4] Alessandra Bernardi et al. “The Hitchhiker Guide to: Secant Varieties and Tensor Decomposition”. en. In: *Mathematics* 6.12 (Dec. 2018), p. 314. ISSN: 2227-7390. DOI: [10.3390/math6120314](https://doi.org/10.3390/math6120314). URL: <https://www.mdpi.com/2227-7390/6/12/314> (visited on 04/15/2025).
- [5] Jerome Brachat et al. “Symmetric tensor decomposition”. en. In: *Linear Algebra and its Applications* 433.11-12 (Dec. 2010), pp. 1851–1872. ISSN: 00243795. DOI: [10.1016/j.laa.2010.06.046](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.laa.2010.06.046). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0024379510003423> (visited on 01/07/2026).
- [6] Maria Chiara Brambilla and Giorgio Ottaviani. “On the Alexander–Hirschowitz theorem”. en. In: *Journal of Pure and Applied Algebra* 212.5 (May 2008), pp. 1229–1251. ISSN: 00224049. DOI: [10.1016/j.jpaa.2007.09.014](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpaa.2007.09.014). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0022404907002344> (visited on 04/15/2025).
- [7] Weronika Buczyńska and Jarosław Buczyński. “Secant varieties to high degree Veronese reembeddings, catalecticant matrices and smoothable Gorenstein schemes”. en. In: *J. Algebraic Geom.* 23.1 (Sept. 2013), pp. 63–90. ISSN: 1056-3911, 1534-7486. DOI: [10.1090/S1056-3911-2013-00595-0](https://doi.org/10.1090/S1056-3911-2013-00595-0). URL: <https://www.ams.org/jag/2014-23-01/S1056-3911-2013-00595-0/> (visited on 12/11/2025).

- [8] Jarosław Buczyński and J.M. Landsberg. “Ranks of tensors and a generalization of secant varieties”. en. In: *Linear Algebra and its Applications* 438.2 (Jan. 2013), pp. 668–689. ISSN: 00243795. DOI: [10.1016/j.laa.2012.05.001](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.laa.2012.05.001). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0024379512003308> (visited on 12/11/2025).
- [9] Sean Carroll. *Spacetime and geometry: an introduction to general relativity*. eng. Cambridge: Cambridge university press, 2019. ISBN: 978-1-108-77038-5.
- [10] Alex Casarotti, Alex Massarenti, and Massimiliano Mella. “On Comon’s and Strassen’s Conjectures”. en. In: *Mathematics* 6.11 (Oct. 2018), p. 217. ISSN: 2227-7390. DOI: [10.3390/math6110217](https://doi.org/10.3390/math6110217). URL: <https://www.mdpi.com/2227-7390/6/11/217> (visited on 09/26/2025).
- [11] Luca Chiantini, Giorgio Ottaviani, and Nick Vannieuwenhoven. “Effective Criteria for Specific Identifiability of Tensors and Forms”. en. In: *SIAM J. Matrix Anal. & Appl.* 38.2 (Jan. 2017), pp. 656–681. ISSN: 0895-4798, 1095-7162. DOI: [10.1137/16M1090132](https://doi.org/10.1137/16M1090132). URL: <https://epubs.siam.org/doi/10.1137/16M1090132> (visited on 09/26/2025).
- [12] Luca Chiantini, Giorgio Ottaviani, and Nick Vannieuwenhoven. “On generic identifiability of symmetric tensors of subgeneric rank”. en. In: *Trans. Amer. Math. Soc.* 369.6 (Nov. 2016), pp. 4021–4042. ISSN: 0002-9947, 1088-6850. DOI: [10.1090/tran/6762](https://doi.org/10.1090/tran/6762). URL: <https://www.ams.org/tran/2017-369-06/S0002-9947-2016-06762-8/> (visited on 11/29/2025).
- [13] Pierre Comon et al. “Symmetric Tensors and Symmetric Tensor Rank”. en. In: *SIAM J. Matrix Anal. & Appl.* 30.3 (Jan. 2008), pp. 1254–1279. ISSN: 0895-4798, 1095-7162. DOI: [10.1137/060661569](https://doi.org/10.1137/060661569). URL: <http://epubs.siam.org/doi/10.1137/060661569> (visited on 09/26/2025).
- [14] Jan Draisma. “Erratum: A Counterexample to Comon’s Conjecture”. en. In: *SIAM J. Appl. Algebra Geometry* 8.1 (Mar. 2024), pp. 225–225. ISSN: 2470-6566. DOI: [10.1137/23M1623781](https://doi.org/10.1137/23M1623781). URL: <https://epubs.siam.org/doi/10.1137/23M1623781> (visited on 01/08/2026).
- [15] Shmuel Friedland. “Remarks on the Symmetric Rank of Symmetric Tensors”. en. In: *SIAM J. Matrix Anal. & Appl.* 37.1 (Jan. 2016), pp. 320–337. ISSN: 0895-4798, 1095-7162. DOI: [10.1137/15M1022653](https://doi.org/10.1137/15M1022653). URL: <http://epubs.siam.org/doi/10.1137/15M1022653> (visited on 10/28/2025).
- [16] J.M. Landsberg and Mateusz Michałek. “Abelian tensors”. en. In: *Journal de Mathématiques Pures et Appliquées* 108.3 (Sept. 2017), pp. 333–371. ISSN: 00217824. DOI: [10.1016/j.matpur.2016.11.004](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.matpur.2016.11.004). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0021782416301301> (visited on 10/28/2025).
- [17] Joseph M. Landsberg. *Tensors: geometry and applications*. eng. Graduate studies in mathematics 128. Providence (R.I.): American mathematical society, 2012. ISBN: 978-0-8218-6907-9.
- [18] Luke Oeding. *Report on “Geometry and representation theory of tensors for computer science, statistics and other areas.”*. en. arXiv:0810.3940 [math]. Oct. 2008. DOI: [10.48550/arXiv.0810.3940](https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.0810.3940). URL: <http://arxiv.org/abs/0810.3940> (visited on 01/06/2026).

- [19] Luke Oeding and Giorgio Ottaviani. “Eigenvectors of tensors and algorithms for Waring decomposition”. en. In: *Journal of Symbolic Computation* 54 (July 2013), pp. 9–35. ISSN: 07477171. DOI: [10.1016/j.jsc.2012.11.005](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jsc.2012.11.005). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0747717113000047> (visited on 12/17/2025).
- [20] Anna Seigal. “Ranks and symmetric ranks of cubic surfaces”. en. In: *Journal of Symbolic Computation* 101 (Nov. 2020), pp. 304–317. ISSN: 07477171. DOI: [10.1016/j.jsc.2019.10.001](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jsc.2019.10.001). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S074771711930104X> (visited on 11/14/2025).
- [21] Yaroslav Shitov. “A Counterexample to Comon’s Conjecture”. en. In: *SIAM J. Appl. Algebra Geometry* 2.3 (Jan. 2018), pp. 428–443. ISSN: 2470-6566. DOI: [10.1137/17M1131970](https://doi.org/10.1137/17M1131970). URL: <https://epubs.siam.org/doi/10.1137/17M1131970> (visited on 09/26/2025).
- [22] Yaroslav Shitov. “COMON’S CONJECTURE OVER THE REALS”. en. In: (2020).
- [23] Yaroslav Shitov. “Higher rank substitutions for tensor decompositions. I. Direct sum conjectures”. en. In: (2024). DOI: [10.13140/RG.2.2.21768.43528](https://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.21768.43528). URL: <https://rgdoi.net/10.13140/RG.2.2.21768.43528> (visited on 10/15/2025).
- [24] Yaroslav Shitov. “Higher rank substitutions for tensor decompositions. II. Comon’s conjecture”. en. In: (2024). DOI: [10.13140/RG.2.2.17574.13125](https://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.17574.13125). URL: <https://rgdoi.net/10.13140/RG.2.2.17574.13125> (visited on 10/15/2025).
- [25] Karen E. Smith, ed. *An invitation to algebraic geometry*. en. Corrected printing. Universitext. New York Berlin Heidelberg: Springer, 2004. ISBN: 978-0-387-98980-8.
- [26] Ravi Vakil. *The rising sea: foundations of algebraic geometry*. eng. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2025. ISBN: 978-0-691-26867-5 978-0-691-26868-2.
- [27] Kexin Wang and Anna Seigal. “Lower bounds on the rank and symmetric rank of real tensors”. en. In: *Journal of Symbolic Computation* 118 (Sept. 2023), pp. 69–92. ISSN: 07477171. DOI: [10.1016/j.jsc.2023.01.004](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jsc.2023.01.004). URL: <https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0747717123000044> (visited on 02/19/2026).
- [28] Xinzhen Zhang, Zheng-Hai Huang, and Liqun Qi. “Comon’s Conjecture, Rank Decomposition, and Symmetric Rank Decomposition of Symmetric Tensors”. en. In: *SIAM J. Matrix Anal. & Appl.* 37.4 (Jan. 2016), pp. 1719–1728. ISSN: 0895-4798, 1095-7162. DOI: [10.1137/141001470](https://doi.org/10.1137/141001470). URL: <http://epubs.siam.org/doi/10.1137/141001470> (visited on 09/26/2025).

Department of Mathematics
Celestijnenlaan 200B
3001 LEUVEN (HEVERLEE), BELGIË
tel. + 32 16 32 70 07
fax + 32 16 32 79 98
wis.kuleuven.be

